



Eat Drink Man Woman

Introduction

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"To eat is to appropriate, to take into ourselves the lives of others. The act of eating is not only the most basic of necessities, but also the most profound of moral acts."

— John Berger, *The Eaters and the Eaten*

Eating is one of the first ways humans learn to share, to care, and to communicate. Every meal carries not only flavor but meaning: gestures of affection, habits of family, memories of love and loss. In this theme we consider food as an ethical and emotional language: how what we eat, and how we share it, reflects our values and relationships.

Overview

In *The Eaters and the Eaten*, Berger laments that modern life has **"severed the ancient conversation between men and animals,"** turning sustenance into transaction and isolating the act of eating from gratitude. Yet, he also insists that food still carries the memory of togetherness, a "pledge that all would live."

Ang Lee's *Eat Drink Man Woman* (1994) brings that pledge to life in a modern, urban setting. Each Sunday, a retired chef prepares elaborate meals for his three daughters in Taipei. The table becomes a site of ritual and tension, a space where love is expressed wordlessly through cooking, even as unspoken desires pull the family apart.

Food here is ethical not because of what is eaten, but because of how it binds people in care and duty. Ang Lee's lens finds morality in the everyday act of feeding others, a quiet echo of Berger's belief that to share food is to share life.

Class Schedule

Class 1 — Film Screening: *Eat Drink Man Woman*

- Short introduction to John Berger's "The Eaters and the Eaten"
- Screening of *Eat Drink Man Woman* (123 min; view in class or split across sessions)
- Viewing notes:
 - How does the film portray food as communication?
 - What moral or emotional meanings are attached to the act of cooking?
 - How does the ritual of eating together both unite and divide the family?

Class 2 — Discussion: The Table as Moral Space

- Discussion linking Berger's essay and the film:
 - In what sense is cooking a moral or ethical act?
 - How does the film balance appetite, tradition, and individuality?
 - What does Berger mean by "the sharing of bread," and how is this visible in the film's family rituals?
- Visual pairings for comparison:
 - **Leonardo da Vinci**, *The Last Supper* — the meal as communion
 - **Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin**, *The Kitchen Maid* — quiet ethics of labor
 - **Norman Rockwell**, *Freedom from Want* — domestic ideal and moral image
 - **Rirkrit Tiravanija**, *Untitled (Free)* — cooking as shared social art
 - **Martha Rosler**, *Semiotics of the Kitchen* — critique of gendered domesticity

Class 3 — Reflection and Response

- Short written reflection: *What does food reveal about care and obligation?*
- Group discussion: when does nourishment become art, and when does it become control?

- Optional creative response: photograph or sketch a meal that expresses a personal relationship — not for display, but as a private meditation on connection and gratitude.

Selected Quotes from John Berger, "The Eaters and the Eaten"

"To eat is to take into oneself the life of another; but in the modern world, the eater devours not only food but the world itself."

"The sharing of bread was once a pledge that all would live; today, food is divided to prove who owns it."

"The act of eating is both necessity and moral choice."

"The sharing of food is the first form of justice."